

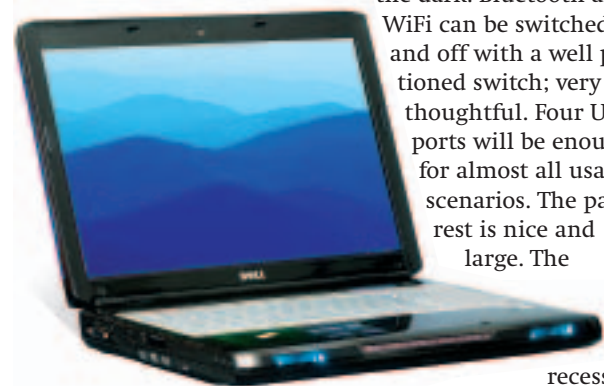


Dell XPS 1730

Lap Busting Hardcore Performer

Large and lovely — initial impressions. Never before have we seen such components under the hood of a mere notebook it is; at 17-inches with a large bezel, this monster weighs in at just under five kilograms. Its aimed at LAN party freaks and gamers who want limited portability; certainly nobody

although this isn't apparent immediately, but becomes more evident once you spend some time using it. Keypad feedback is right on; as is the ergonomics and we have absolutely no complaints. There are also large and blue backlit, chromed multimedia buttons on the front of the notebook which work well and are usable in the dark. Bluetooth and WiFi can be switched on and off with a well positioned switch; very thoughtful. Four USB ports will be enough for almost all usage scenarios. The palm rest is nice and large. The



who wants to cart his notebook around everyday ever will. If you want compact; skip this review now! We'd call it a desktop replacement but its clearly oriented towards the gaming fraternity; which makes it somewhat of a rarity.

Its colossal bulk aside, the XPS 1730 is quite a looker. With a solid body that has a mock carbon fibre finish and solid build quality all round you can be sure of a long lasting product. The screen is very crisp and has great viewing angles, while the resolution of 1920 x 1200 pixels may be considered to be too high for a 17-inch screen; we respect the fact that this was a necessity for what is essentially a gaming notebook. The keypad is also very well laid out

recessed but sensitive trackpad works well.

There's a little monochrome LCD display below the right hinge that works like a small status display showing the time, CPU and memory utilisation among other parameters. Powered by an X9000 Core 2 Extreme Edition CPU that runs at 2.8 GHz, the XPS 1730 has enough processing grunt to handle nearly anything you can throw at it. The price of this CPU alone is in the region of Rs 60,000 so be prepared to an unpleasant surprise when you read this behemoths price. The configuration we received also had 4 GB of DDR 2 667 MHz memory and two NVIDIA GeForce 8800 GTX graphics cards in SLI (Yes! You read that last part right). You can also upgrade to a 500 GB x 2

RAID 0 hard drive solution; and Dell offers an 80 GB SSD solution too, although this is prohibitively expensive at the moment.

With such components we expected performance to be shattering; while not on par with the fastest desktops around, the fact that Dell was able to get two of the fastest mobile graphics solutions under this things hood itself speaks volumes about their design. Obviously this notebook dissipates a lot of heat and the rear portion gets very hot; but through the vents large fins are visible which evidently do a good job; as the palm rest does not heat up at all.

We tested the mighty XPS 1730 with a plethora of benchmarks and here's what we got:

The XPS 1730 scores more than the average gaming PC; with a mighty 12735 in 3D Mark 2006. Its hard drive index of 50 MB/s is also better than the average notebook; their scores usually do not exceed 40 MB/s. It does very well at gaming; its bread and butter and is easily the fastest gaming notebook out there. Battery life is a measly one hour 15 minutes with SLI on and one and a half hours with SLI off; gaming without mains power means your battery will run out in 35 minutes; well its better than your gaming rig and UPS!

So it's fast; and expensive. The configuration we got costs around Rs 2,00,000; which is definitely very high for a notebook. While its true that

Benchmarks	Scores
PC Mark 2005 Overall	7683
CPU	7006
Memory	519
Graphics	12482
HDD	4809
3D Mark 2006 Overall	12735
CPU Score	2546
Doom 3 (1600 x 1200)	120.6
Doom 3 (640 x 480)	149.7
COH (1920 x 1200)	46.6
COH (1024 x 768)	351.4
S.T.A.L.K.E.R (1680 x 1050)	121.3
SiSoft Sandra 2008	
Dhrystone	25881
Whetstone	20551
Multimedia Integer	154215
Multimedia Floating	84257
HDD Index	50 MB/s
Memory Integer	4597 MB/s
Memory Floating	4612 MB/s
Wprime (sec, less is better)	54.551 sec

you could assemble a PC that's thrice as powerful for the same price its equally true that no other notebook available in India can even hope to approach this sort of performance. If you have the moolah, are looking for something exclusive by nature of its very price and desire a gaming notebook that stands out at your next LAN fest; you may have found just the thing.

Specifications

CPU — Core 2 Extreme X9000 (2.8 GHz), 4 GB RAM (DDR2 667 MHz), GeForce 8800 GTX x 2 SLI, 200 GB (7200 rpm) HDD, screen — 17 inches, 1920 x 1200 pixels.

Contact: Dell India
Phone No: 1800-425-4026 / 080-2506-8026
Email: online_india@dell.com
Website: www.dell.co.in
Price: Rs 1,99,200

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★☆☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Sony Ericsson Xperia X1

Was It Worth The Wait?

Few items generate interest like the SE Xperia X1 did. This was also to be our first look at Windows Mobile (WM) 6.1. Our first reaction on un-boxing it was "Wow, it's a lot smaller than we imagined." It's very compact for a side-slider phone with a QWERTY keyboard and a 3-inch, 800x480 pixel screen.

The X1 feels solid. The brushed metal finish (black in this model, but silver is also available) resists smudges; the screen, however, doesn't.

After a slow boot-up, we noticed that although most of the body is metallic, the front buttons are plastic. The stylus fits in perfectly with the body — no chance of pulling this out of your pocket and losing a stylus.

The high-resolution screen is one of the best we've seen. It's crisp, crystal clear and no complaints even in direct sunlight. Our first complaint — you have to tap a lot harder than normal.

The phone was quite responsive when going to settings and menus — not Symbian fast, but fast compared to other WM devices. No Walkman software here; WM player handles media and some files would hang the player for a few seconds; we suspect a software bug. Wide-screen format videos play flawlessly, and look really good on the X1.

Opera is the default browser; IE is still available but you have to select it from the menu. The 5-way navigation button on the X1 acts like a touch control, with four actual clicks on either

side. The centre button is like a trackpad, but without a mouse cursor. Although the centre button is meant to scroll through long pages and links, we found the stylus and the click buttons just offer more control.

The slider is ultra slick and the QWERTY keypad is quite impressive to look at, and since each button has a triangular-shaped raised part, it's also quite easy to find the right keys. Key feedback is lacking, so again, there's a little bit of a learning curve involved.

The X1 allows you to choose different looks and layouts for the WM Today screen, and they call this feature X-panels.

The first time we inserted the SIM card and started it up, the X1 claimed there was no SIM. When trying to remove the SIM, it ended up dislodging the chip from the plastic that holds it; SIM retention is not ideal.

Connectivity is the X1's forte, with all the options you can think of — Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, GPRS, Edge, GPS, etc. Thanks to WM 6.1, and its new Connection manager, it's really easy to switch off or on different connections. We tested the X1's Wi-Fi and GPRS connectivity, and found that it all worked flawlessly.

Once we got it working, the network reception was good; not as good as Nokia's N-series, but still commendable. Voice clarity was exceptional when on a call, and people at both ends could hear each other clearly. The ear piece volume and clarity of the X1 are also impressive.

Running WM means that mobile MS Office is available, and you have a very long list of office related apps to choose from.

It's actually the quality of the screen that makes this the

perfect PDA-phone. Working with documents and e-mail are a joy. You will enjoy the clarity that the screen offers at even miniscule font sizes.

The 3.2 MP main camera is nowhere close to as good as the cameras we've become used to. The 3.5 mm headset jack on the top of the device is something we've been waiting for from SE, and is good to have for those who want to connect a better set of headphones than the bundled ones. The provided headset offers decent quality, but the audio quality improves drastically a set of EP630s.

The light sensor works so well that you never notice any drastic changes in screen brightness and the screen clearly visible at all times. Speaking of lighting, multi-colour LEDs at each of the four corners of the sides of the phone look cool and illuminate when starting up or when you are notified of an event such as a message or a missed call.

Memory expansion is needed, because the device only features 512 MB ROM, and this is taken care of by a Micro SD slot that's below the battery cover, but not below the battery — so no need to power down the device to insert / remove the memory.



Priced at Rs 44,500 the Xperia is expensive. Sure you get WM 6.1 device with a decently fast processor and RAM. Yes this device is unique, and definitely offers amazing flaunt value; it's also true that you get a really nice PDA / Smart phone with an impressive screen but a Netbook and a good phone would probably be much better as solutions for those who need to work on the move, and they'd be cheaper too! If it's available for around the Rs 30K mark, it's something you really should own.

Read the full review on www.thinkdigit.com

Specifications

WM 6.1 Pro, CPU — Qualcomm MSM7200A (528 MHz), 512 MB ROM, 256 MB RAM, Screen — 3-inch (800x480), 65k colours, 3.2 MP Auto Focus camera, A-GPS, BT 2.0, WLAN, microSD expansion, 1500 mAh battery, weight — 158 g

Contact: Sony Ericsson
Phone: 39011111
Website: www.sonyericsson.com
Price: Rs 44,500

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★☆☆
Overall	★★★★☆